

software; it is a learning program. So it learns and then gives results. People like us, who design and develop the software, cannot predict what it will lead to. We can explain why it did a particular thing and that is exactly what we tried to build. Because what we realised was it was such a big, people-oriented, perception-oriented, locally sensitive field. We cannot play the role of God; what is happening is defined by the market and the best we can do is capture the market's feeling, take it as a learning, and build our software and our logic based on that market perception.

"So if you look at it broadly, there are three main areas where we help: any search happens on a software called Ginio, which is an end-to-end solution. The website is based on Ginio, and the people who take calls are on different models of Ginio. This is a home-grown solution and it is based on the CLAMP stack. We also use a lot of Python and various open source projects based on these languages. We use a search engine called Sphinx, which is a C-based search engine. We use MySQL to optimise the search, and we tweak the basic kernel of MySQL for that function. We develop a lot of code and give it back to the community in all these projects. So if we develop something that is not our business' focus, but is a performance enhancer or a set-up, we give it back to the community."

### The challenges

Although Justdial is not a regular open source company, yet

one of the challenges it faces is a pretty regular one... the lack of talent. Sandipan says, "One major issue I faced was getting the second level of people and expanding the team. There are not too many people well trained in open source technology and who understand the open source philosophy. There are more framework-based developers. We can call them copy artists in simple terms, because they know how to copy codes from various places and run them. There is a lack of real programmers. That is the reason we had to go for an innovative kind of recruitment process. So we don't take people based on their programming skills. We test their statistics, logics and pseudo coding skills and then we train them in programming. The problem of a lack of talent remains as it was. But things seem to be changing with time."

What really helped Sandipan drive the whole initiative was his involvement in the technology and in the community. He says, "I have been working on open source technology since 1996. India's first fully open source based model was moneycontrol.com, which I was associated with. That's how I started my life with open source. I have always worked only on open source technology since that time. The challenge of a lack of expertise was not faced by me. I knew the community and, hence, knew a lot of people working on open source technologies. There was 10 years of experience with me with respect to open source technology, and we have cashed in on that in Justdial all the way." **END** 

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